Between Veneration and Loathing

Loving and Hating Documents

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On a crisp winter afternoon in the heart of a national capital, a contingent of soldiers marches through an honor guard down the steps of a public building, bearing several large wooden cases. The servicemen—those carrying the cases are all men, while the honor guard lining the steps is made up entirely of servicewomen—load these crates onto an armored personnel carrier, and a parade steps off down the city's main street, led by the marching bands of all the military branches. After about a mile, they halt in front of another building, and their precious cargo is carried inside under the protection of four guards wielding machine guns. Two days later, the nation's president and chief justice watch as the cases are opened and their contents ceremoniously placed in a shrine of marble and brass so as to permit viewing by an awed public. Every precaution has been taken to protect the contents: with the nation at war, a conflict that threatens to expand to worldwide dimensions, the treasured objects are placed in a bombproof and scientifically controlled environment. Every night they will be lowered automatically into a secure shelter deep underground. In the great columned hall, the president delivers a patriotic address. “We are engaged here today in a symbolic act,” he says, acclaiming the objects of attention and “enshrining [them] for future ages.” What are those objects? The bodies of heroes from the past? The national gold reserves? No, they are six brown and wrinkled sheets of parchment, one of them virtually illegible, bearing the florid script of a previous century and a number of signatures, many of them also unreadable.[1]

Now picture a second scene, far more chaotic, but in its way no less solemn. Unruly crowds have been gathering nightly in the streets of another national capital. The government, once the absolute master of its people, is crumbling but desperate to hold onto power. The tide of popular will has turned against it, however, and, with the signal that a potent foreign ally will no longer sustain the local repressors with invading tanks, the populace is stirred to new courage. Their anger comes to focus on two particular objects. The first is a massive wall of concrete and barbed wire, built to keep the city's inhabitants in and the desire for freedom out, after too many citizens had sought escape across the border; eventually the people will dance defiantly on the wall, hammer it down, and take home fragments as grisly souvenirs. The second target of hatred is an unlikely one: a drab office building in another part of the city. After a few nights of chanting outside, the crowd finally surges into the building, driving the guards away and breaking up the furniture. They make first for the banal tools of tyranny: plain metal filing cabinets, filled with paper of unassuming appearance. Impulsively, the invaders pull open the drawers, scatter the files on the floor, and stomp on them or grind them under foot, feeling the emotional satisfaction of abusing these instruments of their former abusers. Very few of the files are destroyed, however, as the leaders of the crowd move quickly to prevent the burning or shredding of these documents. Indeed, there is evidence that the government agency that had kept the files had already begun to destroy some of them, fearing that they would be turned against it if the spreading revolution were successful; the movement's leaders put an immediate stop to this, envisioning a time when the agents of oppression might be brought to justice. Even in the midst Page 44 → of this revolution (a relatively bloodless one), there was great concern for apparently ordinary pieces of paper.[2]

This second incident is perhaps the more recognizable, since it was carried out before the world only a little over a decade ago. It occurred in Berlin during the revolution of 1989-90, as the German Democratic Republic—such an ironic name!—was collapsing. In addition to its attack on the hated Berlin Wall, the most powerful and, in its day, effective artifact of modern tyranny, the democratic movement targeted the headquarters of the East German secret police, the Stasi, which had for years been compiling minutely detailed surveillance files on citizens and foreign visitors alike. Intended originally to gather specific evidence that could be used against individuals, the Stasi's system of record keeping became a more generalized mechanism for the enforcement of docility in the population: don't even think about opposing the regime, these files silently proclaimed, for someone is watching your every move, and you will pay dearly for the slightest misstep. The first, and more benign, incident took place

in Washington, DC, in December 1952. The American Declaration of Independence and the Constitution were being transferred to the still-new National Archives building from the Library of Congress, where they had been kept and exhibited on and off for years. When President Harry Truman spoke of enshrining these parchments, bland enough in appearance but freighted with emotional power, he knew what he was talking about. Since then, millions of visitors have filed in hushed silence or respectful whispers past the display cases in the great hall of the Archives, and they have gazed feelingly at these “charters of freedom.”

These two episodes have much to say to those who are interested in the larger cultural roles of artifacts, documents, and the other evidences that shape our individual and collective understanding of the past. They are instances in which documents themselves became objects of attention, valued less for their contents than for what they are as physical things. “They are not important as manuscripts,” a former custodian of the Declaration and Constitution had said of them, “they are important as themselves.”[3] The content of these particular records—written words on parchment or paper and, in the case of the Stasi files, records in other formats as well, including photographs and sound recordings—was subsidiary to the records as things, as objects. The words did not lose their meaning or importance, but those words had assumed a secondary position, at least temporarily. That the documents existed was the salient fact, more meaningful than the words in them.

As such, these cases offer an occasion to examine certain assumptions that we often take for granted. Living as we do in an overwhelmingly literate society, one in which the ability to read and write is considered essential, we fall unconsciously into the habit of presuming that documents mean only what the words in them mean. Records are carriers of information, and we presume that the only significant information is the words those documents speak in our mind's ears. In these two cases, however, the words of the documents are relegated to a subordinate importance. Few in the crowd in Berlin stopped to read particular files as they trampled them underfoot; what mattered instead was the emotional release of asserting popular control over those files and the covert operations that had produced them. Similarly, the ringing words of the Declaration of Independence were practically irrelevant during its enshrinement: significantly, no part of the ceremony in 1952 included an actual reading of the text. In fact, it was (and remains) virtually impossible to read the words of the Declaration from the parchment original; for that purpose, reproductions produced from long-ago engravings are more useful. Here, records as mere carriers of information have been replaced by records as artifacts, and it is that connection that I wish to explore here.

Records may be honored as objects—objects of veneration—lovingly preserved, held up for admiration, meant to stir those who behold them to feelings of nobility and devotion. The power of such documentary objects derives not from the words of their texts but from the transformation of these documents into artifacts. Records may also, by contrast, be feared and despised—objects of loathing—hated for what they were intended to accomplish and sometimes actually did. Mistreating or destroying such records springs from an emotion that goes beyond hostility toward the information they contain or the sentiments they express to a generalized revulsion at their very existence. Understanding the many layers of meaning in documents as instruments of social memory requires a consideration of these two poles and of the territory in between. Situating documents between veneration and loathing may provide us with insights that are obscured when we, relentless literates that we are, presume that texts only mean what they say. Sometimes they mean a great deal more.

Veneration

The Declaration of Independence and the Constitution are objects of widespread devotion, visited by thousands Page 45 → of people every year.[4] Most simply glance at them and move on; only a few pause to read a few lines, motivated perhaps by the challenge of deciphering the unfamiliar handwriting. Almost no one takes the time to read the entire texts—they would probably be hurried along by the guards if they attempted to do so—or has an immediate practical need to check the wording. Anyone who wants to see what, for example, the Third Amendment to the Constitution actually says will more likely consult one of the thousands of printed editions, readily available. It is not the wording that attracts here, but the carrier of those words. “That's the actual Declaration of Independence,” parents explain to their children, pointing to it as the “real thing” and perhaps evoking daydreams of being present when it was signed. Viewers may even come away with a false impression of

it. Knowing that Thomas Jefferson was the principal drafter of its text, they may be forgiven for concluding that the handwriting is his, rather than that of the virtually forgotten Timothy Matlack, a clerk of the Continental Congress from Pennsylvania, who most likely prepared the engrossed copy that the delegates signed, a month after its adoption.[5] The tourists have perhaps been drawn to the National Archives in the first place by their familiarity with the text, but in the document's presence they focus on its existence as much as its contents.

Foundational political documents such as these have broad emotional attraction, for citizens and others alike, and we surround them with patriotic sentiments. At least in Western democracies, written charters have become the basis for self-government, and citizens find reassurance in the mere fact that these political compacts exist. They can be referred to, even if they seldom are. Such documents now seem so culturally ingrained that we may even prize their symbolic attractions above precise authenticity. The curious history of the state constitution of Massachusetts shows this reverence for documents as objects and the apparent desire to ensure that they will have an appropriately solemn and lofty appearance. Massachusetts boasts that it has the oldest (1780) written constitution in the world that is still in effect; though amended more than a hundred times, the fundamental frame of government and the language ordaining it are still in place. At its adoption, the constitution was engrossed on nine oversize parchment sheets, each about twice the size of that of the Declaration of Independence, and these were displayed throughout the nineteenth century in the office of the secretary of the commonwealth in Boston. By the 1890s, however, the secretary noticed that “in several places the ink has faded so as to be hardly visible”—the result, no doubt, of prolonged exposure to sunlight—and he suggested that the entire document “should be copied without delay.” The legislature appropriated funds so that what it called a perfect copy could be made, and every effort was made to guarantee this perfection. The copy was made on new parchment sheets of identical in size to the originals, and the text was copied by hand so that each line of the new version matched precisely the corresponding line in the old one: if a word in the original was divided over two lines, the same break was made in the copy. The copyist made no attempt to replicate late eighteenth-century orthography, using instead what would have been considered the best contemporary penmanship, but in other respects (bold headings for the various subdivisions of the document, for example) the copy matched the original precisely. The copy was checked repeatedly, both as it was being made and after it was finished, to ensure this faithfulness. The original was then retired to a specially constructed walnut case and eventually to the vaults of the state archives, rarely to be seen again.[6]

For our purposes, however, the real significance of the copy was just beginning. Two aspects of it are particularly noteworthy. First, in authorizing the making of the copy, the state legislature had specifically invested it with “the same force and effect as the original.” Should there ever be a need to consult the actual document, the copy would be the text examined and its wording would be probative. Published versions or any other conceivable use of the constitution would now depend on the 1893 copy, not the 1780 original. Moreover, this new copy was so “perfect” that it was held up for veneration as if it were the original. With the original now safely set aside, the copy was put out for public viewing and, most interesting of all, was displayed without any indication that it was in fact a copy rather than the original. First in the State House itself and later in the museum of the state archives, this copy was presented to the public without explanation, and those who saw it were permitted, perhaps even encouraged, to draw an erroneous conclusion about what they were seeing. The labeling of the document spoke of the 1780 date of the text, and viewers quite naturally assumed that the object they were looking at dated from that year as well. A limited few might be able to tell that the handwriting was from a later time, and anyone who inquired further might be told that this was a copy; others went away thinking they had seen something which in fact they had not.[7] The impulse behind both the copying and the display of that copy tells us much about how we view such documents as culturally valued objects. The Page 46 → desire to see and get close to the venerated documentary object is so strong that, to satisfy it, we may even be willing to bend the historical reality.

Happily, the vision of documents as beloved artifacts is not usually encumbered by such deceptions. Many institutions and organizations accord a place of honor in their headquarters to their charter, often a distinctly ordinary legal document. Like the blessed first dollar earned by a small business, framed behind the counter of the local diner, the documents that call corporate entities into being are revered, less for what they say than for the simple fact that they exist. Colleges and universities seem especially reverent of their charters, usually to no

practical end. In one school I know of, each new president is handed a copy of the charter during the installation ceremony, although the real charter is an act of the state legislature, resting unacclaimed with other legislative documents in the state archives. Still, a ceremonial copy, done up in handsome leather like a diploma, is handed over from one president to the next as a symbol of the transfer of authority. Most of the published histories of universities in this country that I have sampled begin with a description of the document, whether a legislative act or an individual's will, that brought the school (or perhaps an earlier, simpler incarnation of it) into being. Often, the illustrations include a page or two of this same instrument. The standard history of the University of Michigan, for example, describes both the original and revised acts of the legislature that created the Catholepistemiad of Michigan (a word that is hard to fit into a fight song). A history of Holy Cross College in Worcester, Massachusetts, published in the 1960s, reproduces the first and last page of the 1865 “Act to Incorporate the Trustees of the College of the Holy Cross” as the facing endpapers in both the front and back of the volume. Most of the actual text is left out, since the first page of the document is given over mainly to headlines and the last page is taken up almost wholly by the signatures of the governor and legislative leaders. If this document were considered merely as what it actually is—chapter 99 of the Acts of 1865 of the Massachusetts legislature—it would hardly be accorded this place of honor. Instead, it is something more, apparently deserving of attention every time one opens the book of the school's history.[8]

Various kinds of ceremonial uses of documents further underline this reverence for them as something more than texts. A number of Christian denominations use books in processions and other rites, and the Qur'an is reverenced in Islam, but the centrality of Torah scrolls in Jewish worship is the clearest demonstration of the interaction between text and object. The scroll occupies a place of honor in the local community's worship space, and it is accorded deep respect. During sabbath liturgy, it is carried through the sanctuary, and members of the congregation may come forward to kiss it with their fingers, with prayer shawls, or (in a kind of double use of textual artifacts) with their own prayer books. Once the scriptural passage for the day has been read, the scroll is lifted up for all to see before its return to the ark. Text and object are closely connected. The procession and the acts of devotion by the congregation are preludes to the reading of a section of the text. The words obviously matter, since believers understand them to be God's words. Thus the honor of reading them aloud is great, as when a young man symbolically achieves adulthood in the bar mitzvah ceremony by reading the text of the day, an honor for which he has practiced for months. Beyond that, however, the scroll is also reverenced as an object because it is the bearer of these words, even when the words are left unspoken. The mere sight of it evokes awe and a desire to live according to its precepts. It is treated with the utmost respect: if damaged (as in a fire, for instance) it is buried as if it were a beloved member of the community—as indeed it is.[9] Thus, scrolls are neither exclusively text nor exclusively object; that they are at least partly the latter ranks them clearly among our documentary objects of veneration.

Such objects assume great importance in personal as well as institutional settings. The collection of autographs, whether by wealthy collectors who seek to amass signatures of the famous or by ordinary schoolchildren who ask classmates to sign their yearbooks, is widespread. The mere possession of the signature of another, as often as not without accompanying text, exerts a powerful attraction. Jeremy Belknap, founder of the Massachusetts Historical Society in 1791, cast a wide net in assembling materials for his cabinet, gathering “specimens of natural and artificial curiosities” as well as books and manuscripts. He was not alone, then or later. A founder of the Maryland Historical Society boasted that he had amassed a collection of the autographs of all the signers of the Declaration of Independence by 1845, barely a decade after the death of the last of them. The assembling of individual archival scraps along with larger bodies of records has been sufficiently widespread that one historian has even identified it aptly as *documania.* How many archives have collections in which the signatures of notable personages have been carefully snipped out, often by nineteenth-century editors of these letters, for trading with their fellow scholars?[10] The desire to possess an autograph Page 47 → is not primarily a desire to possess a text of words with meaning; the expression of best wishes is insignificant, and the too-deliberately clever boilerplate of yearbook inscriptions is not what the holders value. Rather, we prize the thing itself, the name of the person written by that person. The name may be unreadable, but still we know whose it is, and the autograph becomes in a sense both the writer's *and* ours.

Such documentary objects of desire and veneration are not unlike other kinds of artifacts that forge tangible connections with the past. In particular, they are similar to relics, which have been prized for centuries. The relics of saints were part of the Christian tradition—they are present in other religious traditions as well—from the earliest times, and their appeal lay in their power to evoke the presence of a holy man or woman from the past, now held up for veneration and emulation. Entirely mundane on their own (frequently bits of bone, hair, and other decidedly less appealing body parts), relics were invested with meaning by the community of believers because they helped bridge the gap between the earthly and the divine. They were often thought to work particular miracles, and they assumed many liturgical uses: they were embedded in altars, for example, or used for blessing. More broadly, they ensured across time the continuing presence of the saint, a person whose influence with God was understood to be especially efficacious. The desire to possess such tokens led to a flourishing relic trade in the Middle Ages and even to a brisk business in stealing them from one place and taking them to another and, further still, to counterfeiting them. Merely being able to possess them was sufficient because they guaranteed a kind of ongoing contact with their source.[11]

The borderline between relics and documents is a fluid one. In many cases, simple possession is at least nine-tenths of the motivation for our desire to acquire and keep documents as well as relics. As A. S. Byatt demonstrates in her novel *Possession*, we seem to believe that ownership of manuscripts will permit us to gain a kind of access to their writer. The narrator of Henry James's *The Aspern Papers* can eventually recognize his desire for certain letters as a form of documania, but only after his scheming to get his hands on them has led to their destruction. Yes, we care about what such documents may say, but we seem to care at least as much about simply having them. Archives may even contend with one another over the right to hold certain documentary remains. Before the translation of relics in 1952, the Library of Congress and the National Archives had argued quietly for twenty years over custody of the Declaration of Independence and the Constitution. More recently, two institutions engaged in a protracted legal battle over the papers of Martin Luther King Jr. King's papers were divided, in roughly equal proportions, between Boston University (his doctoral alma mater) and the King Center for Nonviolent Social Change in Atlanta. Failing to resolve the dispute, the two institutions finally sued one another, each claiming to be the rightful repository and demanding that the other return their holdings to the proper place. Sadly, neither repository had taken very good care of the portion of the papers it held; neither had processed their collection to any significant degree, making its use by scholars highly problematic. But having the papers was important enough to both institutions that they were willing to expend considerable time and treasure in defending those they already held and trying to get the remainder. The case ended unhappily for all concerned, with the collection still divided between the two institutions and little progress made in organizing them according to accepted professional archival standards.[12]

Possession of cherished records may also be used to support other aspirations. During his years of triumph at the start of the nineteenth century, Napoleon included archival documents in his grand plan to consolidate at Paris the cultural patrimony of Europe. The Louvre was to become the predominant center for the continent's greatest works of art, and a huge central archives was to be built for the historical records not just of the French nation but of conquered lands as well. To this end, more than 3,200 crates containing the records of the papacy, an institution that seemed destined not to survive Bonaparte, were packed and transported to Paris. Some efforts were made to reorganize and recatalog these archives of the Holy See (efforts that only introduced further disorder into an already complex archival arrangement), but improving the usability of these records was hardly the motivation for taking them. Modern notions of scholarship based on extensive use of primary sources were barely in their infancy at the time, and it was not Napoleon's intention to consolidate these and other documents so that the work of historians might be easier. No, he wanted not so much to make an archives as to make a point. The pope and other rulers were now to be consigned to the past, their records preserved as a way of highlighting the world-changing transition that the emperor had wrought. One pope (Pius VI) had died as Napoleon's prisoner; the records of all the popes were now similarly confined. Bonaparte's hopes were short lived, of course, but his actions were replicated in reverse after his downfall. Barely six weeks after Page 48 → his final defeat, the church documents were on their way back to Rome and to the custody of a restored papacy, though nearly a third of them were lost or destroyed in the process.[13] On both sides, the desire to possess the documents as physical things was at least equal to the desire to possess the information they contained.

More sinister examples of the desire for documents as objects are those cases in which they are stolen outright. There have been a number of recent examples in which thieves have removed manuscripts from libraries and archives, sometimes systematically and over a long period of time. One thief managed to accumulate hundreds of Revolutionary, Civil War, and other manuscripts, stolen from such august institutions as the National Archives and the Library of Congress. Though he was finally apprehended when he tried to sell some of them, his motives were not merely financial. Rather, so strongly did he desire these documents that he seems to have stolen them simply to have them.[14] The letters by George Washington and other historical worthies were now *his* and no one else's; that motivation seems to be the common one among criminals who specialize in this particular activity. That the perception of records as revered objects has spun out of control in such cases only underlines the importance of our understanding of them as such. Documents are not merely texts to be read; they are things to be prized in themselves.

Loathing

If we are sometimes attracted to documents, so we may sometimes be repelled by them. The inverse of the desire to venerate and possess documents is the desire to express our contempt for them, to abuse or punish them physically (as in the case of the Stasi files), and even to destroy them. Such hostility toward documents may begin with antagonism toward their contents and the purposes to which they may be put, but these emotions often go considerably beyond such practical concerns. During the French Revolution, for instance, crowds sometimes directed their fury against collections of records because those documents seemed to embody the systems of oppression from which they sought liberation. Since records contained the details of aristocratic privilege, they became likely targets, along with other symbols of entitlement: often, while documents were burned by mob action, coats of arms were torn from public buildings and manor houses plundered. The destruction of such records might bring immediate benefits to the participants, of course, by removing specific evidence of debt or obligations of service. But the enthusiasm that went into the destruction of documents bespeaks a more visceral antagonism. The rural insurrections of 1789 in which documents were burned were driven by motives closely akin to those that led to the strangulation of game birds on lordly estates. There are enough other historical examples of this kind of hostility toward documents—the smashing of Confucian texts during the Cultural Revolution in China in the late 1960s, for instance, and scholars forced to watch as their manuscripts were burned in front of them by Red Guards—to suggest that this is a broadly based impulse.[15]

Often the motivation for loathing documents may be religious. If there are reasons for preserving documents as relics, so there may be a corresponding religious impulse for abusing or destroying them. Medieval relics were sometimes humiliated—taken from their monastic repositories, placed on the floor, and covered for a time with thorns or ashes—if the saint from whom the relic derived failed to perform a desired miracle or answer other prayers. Documents too may be humiliated or even destroyed. In particular, those that contain religious expressions or doctrinal formulations judged to be false or dangerous may be targets. One scholar has recently argued, for example, that it was not generalized warfare that destroyed the legendary library at Alexandria but rather the focused religious disputes among pagans, Christians, and Muslims, each group hoping to purge the texts of the others. During the Reformation, the partisan destruction of offending works of theology and service books was common to nearly all parties. In England, Catholic sacramentaries were special targets of the reformers, as were church inscriptions and gravestones that asked passersby to pray for the dead: since the reform was self-consciously doing away with the popish notion of purgatory, why continue to encourage impiety with such written exhortations? In France, Protestants who posted broadsides denouncing the Mass—the so-called Affair of the Placards of 1534—not only saw them torn down but also suffered retribution and martyrdom themselves. Later, book burning became merely one more familiar form of street theater, used by all sides as a means of party identification. The goal was not merely to silence the voices of heresy, for there were other satisfactions. Burning books and manuscripts was particularly gratifying in these religious contexts because it dramatized the consignment of ideas to the flames, just as other flames were waiting to consume the bodies and souls of the heterodox for all eternity.[16] Nor should we Page 49 → think of these impulses as confined to earlier historical periods; as the destruction of copies of Salman Rushdie's *Satanic Verses* in some countries attests, the desire to destroy the physical carriers of objectionable ideas is always new.

Hostility toward written records may be felt with special intensity by those whose ability to read and write themselves is limited. Because written documents are often made by, interpreted by, and primarily useful to elite groups—especially in societies just undergoing the transition to widespread literacy—records seem inherently to be objects of privilege and therefore targets of those who feel victimized by privilege. To the nonliterate, documents may even seem magical: how can such inconsequential things have so much power? Long experience of disadvantage at the hands of those who control the making and interpreting of documents can breed a lasting suspicion of them among those who lack power. Too often they find themselves in the position of the father of Tom Joad in John Steinbeck's *The Grapes of Wrath.* Just out of prison and seeking a new life for his family, Tom tells a friend how he passed his time in jail. “I learned to write nice as hell,” he says, complete with all sorts of elaborate doodles and calligraphic flourishes, but this was a skill his father would never appreciate. “Pa's gonna be mad when he sees me do that. He don't like no fancy stuff like that. He don't even like word writin'. Kinda scares ‘im, I guess. Ever’ time Pa seen writin', somebody took somepin away from ‘im.” It seems natural to direct one's hatred toward an object, even a mute document, with such potential for harm. The stock melodramatic figure of the villain who cheats a widow out of her inheritance by recourse to a loophole in an obscure document is a familiar enough reminder of the role records may play in such circumstances.[17]

Hatred of documents may often stem from a more general hostility toward their source. The recent case of the prison memoir of Adolf Eichmann illustrates the transfer of hatred from the maker of a record to the record itself. While in an Israeli jail during his war crimes trial, the former Nazi officer filled 1,200 pages with reflections, screeds, self-justifications, and elaborate organizational charts that purported to demonstrate that he was far removed from the planning and execution of the Final Solution. He apparently envisioned publication of this mad apologia, going so far as to leave instructions on how the volume was to be produced—he insisted on elegant pearl-colored covers—and on how his wife was to inscribe gift copies to various old friends. At the time of Eichmann's hanging in May 1962, however, the Israeli prime minister, David Ben Gurion, ordered the manuscript sealed and deposited in the Israeli state archives. The memoir was not destroyed, as it might have been if it had fallen into popular hands, but every effort was made to prevent its dissemination. It was, no doubt, primarily the content that Ben Gurion reviled; lest the memoir excite sympathy for Eichmann, its text had to be held back. But for more than thirty years, the manuscript itself was also kept unavailable. Only after mounting pressure from academics in the United States, Britain, and elsewhere were its contents released, with the hope (the Israeli attorney general said) that the document would in fact undercut those who were now claiming that the Holocaust had never happened. The contempt and detestation was directed principally against the content, but some measure of hostility was also directed against the bearer of that content. Newspapers produced facsimiles of some of its pages, allowing a wider public a view of the hated object.[18]

The parallel case of the bogus Hitler Diaries in the early 1980s shows a similar visceral reaction to documents, though the attitudes with which these bold hoaxes were received ran a wide gamut. When they first emerged, the diaries were treated as prized objects. The German magazine reporter who bought them from the forger was ecstatic when, after protracted negotiations over price, he actually took possession of some of them. “We are the guardians of the Holy Grail,” he enthused, comparing them to the greatest—and equally fanciful—relic of all times. Once the deception began to unravel, however, after duping even so respected a historian as Hugh Trevor-Roper, worldwide popular opinion changed course. Not only were manuscripts exposed as fraudulent, but the various scholars and handwriting experts who had certified them were denounced for having been taken in a little too willingly. Similarly, *Stern* magazine, which had purchased the diaries and published excerpts, was denounced not only for abetting the fraud but also for paying so high a price for the documents in the first place; after rising briefly during the furor, its circulation fell off sharply and advertisers withdrew. In the United States, *Newsweek* was likewise criticized for hyping the diaries even when it was aware of doubts about their authenticity and for deliberately leaking portions to other news outlets in an effort to boost circulation. After the fact, Katherine Graham, owner of the magazine's parent company, admitted feebly that contributing, financially and otherwise, to the deception “bothered us.”[19] Today, the Hitler diaries are viewed not so much with overt hatred as with contempt, directed both at the Page 50 → texts and at those who were so ready to believe them real.

Coming to loathe documents and to seek their destruction may also take a number of more benign but still meaningful forms. Even documents that have no sinister intent and derive from no evil source may become fit

targets for deliberate destruction. Sometimes relief rather than anger is the motivation, but the destruction of documents may still bring genuine satisfactions. Few homeowners, for example, feel any overt hostility toward their mortgage, either as a documentary object or as a text. Almost none have ever actually read the full text, I suspect. And yet, once it has been paid off, do they not happily burn it, often gathering family and friends for this celebratory purpose? The act is purely symbolic, marking a kind of financial independence, and yet it is an act that centers around the destruction of a document. Personal correspondence may evoke similar emotions, though these may be more complex. A former student has related to me a story that still lives in his family. His father and uncles, the sons of Italian immigrants, had written home regularly during their service in the European theater during World War II. When they arrived back home at the war's end, their father, the family patriarch, ordered a sister to shred all the letters into confetti.[20] The hearts of historians and archivists sink at the scene, but perhaps we can understand the motivation nonetheless. When first received, the letters had been cherished—read and reread, passed around to remote members of the family and to neighbors for the reassurance they gave that the boys were unharmed. Once the soldiers safely returned, however, destroying their letters became a way to put the anxieties of war behind them all. What satisfaction the family felt at never again having to be reminded of those worrisome times. Consigning the letters to the bottom of a drawer or a soon-forgotten shoebox was insufficient; nothing less than their outright destruction was necessary for the emotional release it brought. This simple case attests to the powerful proportions that the loathing of records may, even temporarily, assume.

Indifference

Between veneration and loathing, of course, lies indifference. Archivists, particularly those who work in institutional settings, may need few reminders of indifference toward documents, for most of them have their own, often painful, examples of important records that were shunted aside and forgotten. The lack of interest of superiors in taking proper care of records and documentation is all too familiar. Still, a brief consideration of indifference toward records serves to highlight the poles of veneration and loathing and to demonstrate the range of reactions we have toward documents.

Documents that are now objects of veneration may once have been treated with indifference or even a kind of unthinking disdain. Here again, the Declaration of Independence has an instructive history. The relic enshrined in 1952 had suffered many indignities earlier in life. In the nineteenth century, though officially in the custody of the state department, it was often passed from hand to hand. Most of the time, the Great Expression (as it was sometimes called) resided in the building that housed the patent office. This locale was chosen because the building was thought to be fireproof—in fact, it burned to the ground only months after the document had been placed at the state department in 1877, upon its return from Philadelphia for the Centennial celebration—and because exhibit space was available for the display of various contraptions and gizmos that had been filed along with patent applications. When the Declaration was first transferred, together with the Constitution, to the Library of Congress in 1921, the librarian drove across town in a mail truck, laid the documents on some empty canvas sacks in the truck bed and returned to the library, where he rolled the parchments up and put them in the safe in his office, along with the petty cash.[21] How far this ignominious treatment was from the honor guard, the parade, and the inspiring oratory of thirty years later.

What had changed? The Declaration had always been, as the librarian had said with homey familiarity, the real McCoy, but why had it come to be treasured as an artifact as it had not been before? The mere passage of time surely played a role. The events surrounding its adoption and signing had, by the middle of the twentieth century, long since crossed over into the remote past, unremembered by anyone then alive; nor was there anyone living who could have met or heard the stories of someone who had participated in the heady events of July and August 1776. Because the document itself, like a relic, was now one of the few objects that could provide direct personal connection to those events, it had a redoubled value. Because it had survived from those historic times and so little else had, it was a tangible link between past and present. Because it had played so central a part in those formative national events—it was the document that called the nation into being, even if its expressions Page 51 → had to be vindicated in war—it could no longer be ignored. Beyond that, the immediate context in which the Declaration came to be venerated also played a critical role. The climate of the Korean War and the Cold War enhanced reverence for all the charters of freedom, especially as the United States saw itself increasingly in the midst of a

deadly serious competition with totalitarianism and unfreedom. The tensions of the early 1950s certainly accounted for the military protection and honor guard that conveyed the Declaration and the Constitution from one repository to the other, and they also helped explain the bombproof shelter in which the documents were secured every night. Ordinary citizens were beginning to build bomb shelters in their basements and backyards; could they tolerate anything less for the sacred national relics?

The passage of time and changing contexts also explain other transitions from indifference to veneration, but they are not wholly satisfactory since we continue to ignore many documents. The paradoxes of historic building preservation are instructive here. Beginning in earnest in the early twentieth century, efforts to preserve historic structures, to restore them to the look and condition of some real or imagined original state, and to open them for admiration by tourists took hold nearly everywhere in the United States. The motives for this aspect of what David Lowenthal has called the heritage crusade are many and complex: a search for stability in the face of rapid change, the rootlessness of increasingly mobile societies, perhaps even a hostility toward modern technology. For our purposes, the noteworthy thing about the passion for preserving historic buildings and neighborhoods is that it is so often unaccompanied by a comparable passion for preserving the records of the people and institutions who occupied those buildings. Boston, for example, had an active program of historic building preservation, supported with public funds, by the time of the Second World War, but it had no formal archives program for city records until the late 1980s. Of course, archivists would argue that proper custody and organization of documentary evidence facilitates the work of restoring historic structures. But the energy directed toward certain cultural artifacts was not forthcoming for others.[22]

Indifference also seems to infect our attitude toward documents that might even now be identified as objects of possible veneration later on. It is impossible to predict future interests, of course, but certain obvious candidates for treatment as valued artifacts are ignored in the present. Just as we wonder how nineteenth century office-holders could have been indifferent to the Declaration of Independence, so may future historians and curators wonder about us. Especially as technological change transforms the materiality and (perhaps) the nature of documents and records, we may be at risk of leaving gaps in our understanding of these important shifts. Where, for example, is the first successful Xerox copy, confected in October 1938 in Queens, New York? Who has kept copies of the various incarnations of floppy disks, which in a few short years have come in eight-inch, five-inch, three-inch, and smaller sizes? Apart from the more difficult questions of whether the data on these disks is still readable or whether the hardware to accomplish the task of reading is available, not many of the objects themselves survive. Some efforts have been made to archive—usage of the word itself has become increasingly slippery—e-mail messages and Web pages, but the future may still look back on our care of these transformative things as lacking the attention they deserved. We cannot escape either our times or our own history, but we should nonetheless be on watch for our own indifferences, as well as our veneration and our loathing.[23]

Conclusion

It is now twenty years since Frank Burke first called on archivists to consider the fundamental nature of their profession, to examine the basic questions too easily shunted aside in the press of everyday activity. Why are there documentary records in the first place? Why do humans make these records that archivists collect and scholars study? What is their nature, their meaning, and how do we get at those qualities? What is the balance between practical and emotional motivation in record making, record keeping, and record using?[24] Even after two decades, we are still just beginning to explore those questions, and I hope that the foregoing, perhaps impressionistic, consideration of our reactions to documents as objects will assist that exploration.

There are ways in which records and documents come to mean more than what the words in them say. Whether as objects of veneration, of loathing, or of indifference, documents are not as sharply distinct from other kinds of cultural artifacts as those of us who work with them sometimes assume. All are carriers of information, but it is information that operates on a number of different levels at the same time, information that is both literate and nonliterate. Those who encounter such documentary artifacts—whether archivist, scholar, curator, or anyone else—ignore those different levels at their peril. Interdisciplinary conversations are of course helpful in advancing that process. But we must each also train our own self-awareness to look more deeply at these objects

to which we devote our individual forms of attention. This vision will be equally beneficial to archivists who acquire, organize, and make them available, to scholars who use them to construct meanings of past or present experience, and to curators who care for them because they have the power to make connections that cannot be so well captured in words.

NOTES

1. Milton O. Gustafson, "The Empty Shrine: The Transfer of the Declaration of Independence and the Constitution to the National Archives," *American Archivist* 39 (July 1976): 271–85; Donald R. McCoy, *The National Archives: America's Ministry of Documents, 1934–1968* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 1978), 254–56. Though it was enshrined with the other two documents, the Bill of Rights was not part of the transfer parade because it was already in the possession of the National Archives.
2. See the accounts in the *New York Times*, December 6–8, 1989, and January 16, 1990. Earlier efforts by the keepers of these records to destroy them before the crowd broke in to save them are recounted in Timothy Garton Ash, *The File: A Personal History* (New York: Random House, 1997), 20.
3. Archibald MacLeish, former Librarian of Congress, quoted in Gustafson, "Empty Shrine," 277.
4. At this writing, it was in fact not possible to view these documents because the National Archives was renovating and redesigning the hall where they are displayed. The documents are now on view again.
5. The best recent history is Pauline Maier, *American Scripture: Making the Declaration of Independence* (New York: Knopf, 1997).
6. *Second Report of the Secretary of the Commonwealth of Massachusetts for the Year Ending December 31, 1893* (Boston, 1894), 13; *Third Annual Report of the Secretary of the Commonwealth of Massachusetts for the Year Ending December 31, 1894* (Boston, 1895), 15. On changes in orthographic styles, see Tamara Plakins Thornton, *Handwriting in America: A Cultural History* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1996).
7. Chapter 58 of the Resolves of 1894, Original Papers, Archives of the Commonwealth of Massachusetts, Boston. I myself tacitly participated in this deception when I worked at the state archives in the middle 1970s; I like to think that I would not do so now, but I'm not entirely sure. Today, neither the original constitution nor the copy is regularly displayed in the new state archives building (opened 1985), so the deception has stopped.
8. Howard H. Peckham, *The Making of the University of Michigan, 1817–1992*, Margaret Steneck and Nicholas H. Steneck, eds. (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 1967; repr. 1994), 5–13; Walter J. Meagher and William J. Grattan, *The Spires of Fenwick: A History of the College of the Holy Cross, 1843–1963* (New York: Vantage Press, 1966), endpapers. Concern for its charter may have redoubled significance in the latter case, since Holy Cross, a Jesuit school, spent twenty years fighting with a nativist legislature to secure the legal warrant to grant degrees; ibid., 49–57, 103–7. Many other schools have similar tales about their fight for legal recognition.
9. For a description of the ceremonial uses of Torah scrolls, see Abraham E. Millgram, *Jewish Worship* (Philadelphia: Jewish Publication Society, 1971), esp. 179–81, 327–28.
10. The coinage of *documania* belongs to David D. Van Tassel, *Recording America's Past: An Interpretation of the Development of Historical Studies in America, 1607–1884* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1960), 103–10. On the motives of early collectors, see Louis L. Tucker, *The Massachusetts Historical Society: A Bicentennial History, 1791–1991* (Boston: Massachusetts Historical Society, 1995), 24–28; and Richard J. Cox, "Other Atlantic States: Delaware, Florida, Georgia, Maryland, New Jersey, and South Carolina," in H. G. Jones, ed., *Historical Consciousness in the Early Republic: The Origins of State Historical Societies, Museums, and Collections, 1791–1861* (Chapel Hill: North Caroliniana Society, 1995), esp. 103–6. The first archival collection I ever processed, the papers of Charles Campbell (in the archives and special collections department of the Swem Library of the College of William and Mary, Williamsburg, VA), a mid-nineteenth century historian of Revolutionary Virginia, contained many letters from Campbell to other historians, including Jared Sparks and George Bancroft, openly offering to trade duplicate signatures that had been clipped from original letters.
11. The best contemporary treatment of the power and importance of relics is Patrick J. Geary, *Furta Sacra: Thefts of Relics in the Central Middle Ages* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1978).

12. I have described this whole affair in “Archives on Trial: The Strange Case of the Martin Luther King, Jr., Papers,” in Richard J. Cox and David A. Wallace, eds., *Archives and the Public Good: Accountability and Records in Modern Society* (Westport, CT: Quorum, 2002), 21–35. On the general desire to possess the past, see David Lowenthal, *The Past Is a Foreign Country* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1985), esp. 13–21.
13. Owen Chadwick, *Catholicism and History: The Opening of the Vatican Archives* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1978), 14–19; see also Francis X. Blouin Jr. et al., *Vatican Archives: An Inventory and Guide to the Historical Documents of the Holy See* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1998), xx–xxii.
14. Theresa Galvin, “The Boston Case of Charles Merrill Mount: The Archivist's Arch Enemy,” *American Archivist* 53 (Summer 1990): 442–50. On this subject generally, see Gregor Trinkaus-Randall, *Protecting Your Collections: A Manual of Archival Security* (Chicago: Society of American Archivists, 1995), esp. ch. 2.
15. Judith M. Panitch, “Liberty, Equality, Posterity? Some Archival Lessons from the Case of the French Revolution,” *American Archivist* 59 (Winter 1996): 30–47, describes several instances of revolutionary hostility toward records; see also Carl Page 53 → Lokke, “Archives and the French Revolution,” *American Archivist* 31 (March 1968): 23–31. On the deliberate destruction of books, manuscripts, and other documents during the Cultural Revolution, see John King Fairbank, *The Great Chinese Revolution, 1800–1985* (New York: Harper and Row, 1986), 335–37.
16. See examples of this sort of behavior in Eamon Duffy, *The Stripping of the Altars: Traditional Religion in England, 1400–1580* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1992), 492–93; Brad S. Gregory, *Salvation at Stake: Christian Martyrdom in Early Modern Europe* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1999), 90–91; and Barbara S. Diefendorf, *Beneath the Cross: Catholics and Huguenots in Sixteenth-Century Paris* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1991), 56, 65. On the destruction of the legendary library of the ancient world, see Diana Delia, “From Romance to Rhetoric: The Alexandrian Library in Classical and Islamic Traditions,” *American Historical Review* 97 (December 1992): 1449–67. On the humiliation of relics, see Geary, *Furta Sacra*, 20–21.
17. John Steinbeck, *The Grapes of Wrath* (New York: Penguin Books, 1992; repr. 1992), 73–74. For a graphic image of how records may be used to take advantage of the weak, see the nineteenth-century engraving “A Flaw in the Title,” reproduced in James M. O'Toole, *Understanding Archives and Manuscripts* (Chicago: Society of American Archivists, 1990), 14.
18. See, for example, Lee Hockstadter, “Israelis Release Eichmann's Memoirs,” *Washington Post*, March 1, 2000; and Peter Edidin, “Eichmann's House: The Bureaucracy of Murder,” *New York Times*, March 5, 2000.
19. The best general narrative of this entire episode is Charles Hamilton, *The Hitler Diaries: Fakes That Fooled the World* (Lexington: University Press of Kentucky, 1991); the quote from the reporter, Gerd Heidemann, is on page 40. See also Robert Harris, *Selling Hitler* (New York: Pantheon, 1986); the quotation from Graham is on page 385.
20. This story is told in Stephen C. Puleo, *30,000 Miles From Home: The World War II Journey of Tony Puleo* (Boston: Privately printed, 1997), i–ii.
21. What might be called the physical history of the Declaration is recounted in detail in the *Annual Report of the Librarian of Congress for the Fiscal Year Ending June 30, 1949* (Washington, DC: Government Printing office, 1950), 38–55. This narrative, composed just before the document's transfer to the National Archives, itself bears the odor of indifference, contained as it is, without highlight, in a long section of the report headed “Reference Services.”
22. On the motivations behind historic preservation, see David Lowenthal, *The Heritage Crusade and the Spoils of History* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1998), esp. ch. 1. For an account of the origins of the historic preservation movement, see Michael Holleran, *Boston's “Changeful Times”: Origins of Preservation and Planning in America* (Baltimore, MD: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1998). I am grateful to Helen W. Samuels for first calling to my attention the contrast between the preservation of buildings and the preservation of records.
23. For a sober assessment of what changes and does not change as record formats evolve, see John Seely Brown and Paul Druguid, *The Social Life of Information* (Boston: Harvard Business School Press, 2000), esp. 173–83.

24. Frank G. Burke, “The Future Course of Archival Theory in the United States,” *American Archivist* 44 (Winter 1981): 40–46.